(see Appendix, Afghanistan IV). Indeed, scholars have come to consider the complex's ornamental–structural wholeness to be an overarching characteristic of Shansabani foundations, so that "[i]n Ghurid buildings, architecture *was* the structure and decoration; and decoration and structure were the architecture." The content, calligraphic styles, and variety in materials and techniques of the *madrasa*'s epigraphic program have long been the subjects of discussion and debate, with there being scholarly consensus only on the difficulty of discerning the program's presumably multiple and complex meanings.[42]



Figure 4.6 *Shah-i Mashhad* madrasa: *south façade, detail of inscription. © Photograph Bernt Glatzer* c. *1970. Courtesy of IsMEO, Rome.*

Casimir and Glatzer deciphered the first four verses of Surat al-Fath (Q. XLVIII) in Kufic script on the surviving eastern end of Shah-i Mashhad's monumental south façade, whose imposing central portal carried the Arabic foundation inscription in an even more ornate, plaited Kufic (Figures 4.1 and 4.6).[43] The original symmetry of the façade makes it plausible that the western flank continued with at least three more of the Sura's following verses (Q. XLVIII: 5–7).[44] Much more recently, Najimi deciphered or reinterpreted five previously unread or differently interpreted inscriptions on Shah-i Mashhad's southern and northern façades, in addition to the cursive inscription referring to a deceased male's tomb (cf. above).[45] The other five include the *takbir* of *tashriq*[46] in *thuluth* script on the inner eastern face of the main southern portal (Figure 4.7), below an Arabic Kufic inscription naming, presumably, the master builder, or the one who "completed this building, the servant Ahmad ibn Mahmud" (Figure 4.8). On the extant pier of the northern portal of the complex, Najimi deciphered verses 22–24 of Surat al-Hashr (Q. LIX) in Kufic script, as well as a